



What is a cactus?

Cacti come in all shapes and sizes, but nearly all of them have large swollen stems that allow them to store water. This is because many cacti grow in areas with little or no rainfall for long periods of time. Desert cacti have clever adaptations to help them survive extreme heat and drought, however a few very different cacti live in rain forests.

Summer flower ▶ The monk's hood cactus produces pale yellow flowers throughout the summer. They are pollinated by insects and produce spiky fruits.



Mass of thin roots.

Water is stored in the barrel-shaped stem. Some cacti, such as this one, expand when filled with water and contract when dry.

Inside a monk's hood cactus

Roots ▶ The roots of this cactus spread across a large area and grow close to the surface. They quickly draw in as much water as possible from rain or dew.

